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## 11 DEAD AS MONSOON RAINS DERAIL LIFE IN INDIA'S MAHARASHTRA

Passengers walk along waterlogged railway tracks near Vasai station amid heavy rainfall at Nalasopara East, in Mumbai yesterday. Relentless monsoon rains battered Maharashtra yesterday, killing at least 11 people, crippling road, rail and air transport, and triggering landslides, flooding and building collapses as authorities warned residents to stay indoors and avoid all non-essential travel.

SEE ALSO P11

## Dubai handles 82% more air cargo in May compared with January

Joint Customs, SkyCargo logistics system boosted capacity

DUBAI

BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN  
Chief Reporter

Dubai handled more than 82 per cent higher volumes of imported air cargo in May compared with the start of the year, after Dubai Customs and Emirates SkyCargo introduced an integrated logistics system aimed at keeping essential goods flowing into the UAE and across the Gulf.

The jointly-developed system operates through Dubai International Airport Cargo Village and the Maktoum International Airport Air Cargo Centre, streamlining customs clearance while expanding cargo-handling capacity during a period of heightened regional geopolitical tensions.

According to Dubai Customs, imported cargo handled through the two facilities increased from

2,636  
tonnes of essential  
cargo was moved  
across GCC in May

26.6 million kilograms in January 2026 to 48.3 million kilograms in May, an increase of more than 82 per cent, while average daily volumes rose from 1.24 million kilograms to 2.11 million kilograms over the same period. The initiative was designed to ensure uninterrupted supplies of food, medicines and other essential goods to the UAE and neighbouring Gulf markets, even as global supply chains face disruption.

Abdulla Bin Damithan, Chairman of the Ports, Customs and Free Zone Corporation, said Dubai's response reflected the emirate's long-term strategy of strengthening its position as a trusted global trading and logistics hub. The logistics network also supported regional distribution, with 529 truck

movements in May transporting 2,636 tonnes of essential cargo, including meat, pharmaceutical products and general merchandise, across GCC countries.

### Close coordination

Dr Abdulla Busenad, Director General of Dubai Customs, said close coordination between government entities and strategic partners enabled Dubai to maintain trade flows and ensure the uninterrupted movement of vital goods.

To accelerate processing, Dubai Customs expanded the use of its Green Corridor and Shahn initiatives, which prioritise customs clearance for food, medicines and other critical shipments. Authorities also increased inspection capacity and opened additional clearance windows to reduce congestion.

Badr Abbas, Divisional Senior Vice-President at Emirates SkyCargo, said the collaboration strengthened Dubai's role as a global air cargo and logistics hub while ensuring essential shipments continued moving efficiently.

SEE ALSO P-11

## Emirates passengers eat 64m chocolates a year

Salted caramel remains a big favourite

DUBAI

BY NIVETHA DAYANAND  
Assistant Business Editor

Emirates customers consume more than 64 million pieces of premium chocolate every year. The figure is 4 million higher than the previous year, with the airline also handcrafting around 26 million chocolate desserts annually across Economy, Premium Economy, Business and First Class. Emirates loads around 750,000kg of luxury chocolate giveaways from premium suppliers each year and uses about 260,000kg of chocolate ingredients to create desserts for passengers. Emirates said chocolate consumption has grown



by about 5 per cent year on year. Salted caramel remains one of the airline's most popular flavour pairings, while regional preferences continue to influence what appears on board. Pistachio is a frequent pairing on Middle East routes, while Asian destinations inspire combinations with tropical fruits, yuzu or matcha. Mediterranean-inspired routes may include chocolate with berries or stone fruits.

### NATION

Massive infrastructure push for urban evolution in Abu Dhabi | P 2

### BUSINESS

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### IN FOCUS

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# Gaza's Hamas dissolves its government

TECHNOCRATIC COMMITTEE TO ASSUME CIVILIAN ADMINISTRATION

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.  
Senior Associate Editor

Hamas has dissolved the body that governed the Gaza Strip for nearly two decades, formally stepping aside from civilian administration and paving the way for a technocratic committee to take over under the US-brokered ceasefire plan. The move marks the group's biggest political shift since it seized control of the territory in 2007, although the central issue of its disarmament remains unresolved.

Since the Gaza ceasefire took effect last October, Hamas has repeatedly said it was prepared to relinquish day-to-day governance while retaining its position that disarmament must be addressed separately.

"The head of the government's emergency committee, Mohammed Al Farra, has officially submitted his resignation," Ismail Al Thawabta, head of Hamas's government media office, told AFP.

### Handing over reins

"He has also decided to dissolve the committee to facilitate the administrative and governmental transition to the National Committee for the Administration of Gaza (NCAG)," he said.

The NCAG, established under the US-brokered ceasefire

The NCAG, established under the US-brokered ceasefire framework, is expected to oversee civilian administration after the war.

framework, is expected to oversee civilian administration after the war. Based in Cairo, it says it is ready to assume responsibility once conditions allow, but it has yet to enter Gaza because of Israeli objections. Hamas spokesman Hazem Qassem said the decision was intended to remove "any pretexts for the occupation" and facilitate the transition.

The NCAG said it was ready to govern Gaza. "We affirm that the National Committee for the Administration of Gaza is fully prepared to assume its national responsibilities as soon as the necessary resources and capabilities are available," Ali Shaath, head of the committee, wrote on X. "The fundamental requirements for the committee's success are a single authority, a single law with a clear mandate, and a single armed force under the authority of this single entity."

The Board of Peace said it had taken note of Hamas's announcement and called for all weapons in Gaza to be under the control of the NCAG.

SEE ALSO P4, 6



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